

Water disruption

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QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

After a water outage, damaged pipes or suspected contamination, use sealed bottled or previously stored safe water until you establish the risk. Boil-water, do-not-drink and do-not-use notices mean different things. Boiling kills germs but does not remove fuel, chemicals or radioactive contamination. If notices are unavailable, do not treat clear water or restored pressure as proof of safety.

Do now.

- ☐ **Identify the notice**
01 Find the utility or health department notice for your address, its start time, reason, and permitted uses. Save a screenshot in case service fails.
- ☐ **Match use to the instruction**
02 A boil-water notice generally addresses microbes; follow the authority's boil directions. If the notice says do not drink or do not use, follow those stricter limits and the specified alternative-water instructions.
- ☐ **Protect priority needs**
03 Set aside approved water for drinking, infant formula, medications, tooth brushing, food preparation, and pets, as the notice directs.
- ☐ **Wait for clearance**
04 Do not assume that water is safe because it looks clear or service has returned. Follow flushing or filter replacement instructions after an official all-clear.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If there is no notice after pressure loss, flooding or damaged pipes, use sealed or previously stored safe water while you establish the risk. Do not assume that boiling solves an unknown contamination problem. Label containers and keep drinking water separate from cleaning water.

Watch for.

Do not boil water suspected of chemical or fuel contamination. Boiling can concentrate some contaminants; use the alternative source named in the notice.

People & practical needs.

Include drinking, medicines, infant feeding and food preparation in the safe-water plan. Tell every caregiver which container is clean and which tap uses are restricted

Next decision.

Store water and a printed copy of your utility's alert channel. Know whether anyone in the household needs extra water or cannot use a typical treatment method.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

CDC · [Drinking water advisories](#)

CDC · [Make water safe in an emergency](#)

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/water-disruption/>